INTERVIEW: ASHOK GEHLOT

"Our voters will see the difference we have made"

In an interview with Group Editorial Director **Raj Chengappa** and Deputy Editor **Rohit Parihar,** the incumbent chief minister **Ashok Gehlot** seems confident that there is no significant anti-incumbency against his government and that his bid to win the assembly polls is on track. In a companion interview, BJP leader and Union minister **Gajendra Singh Shekhawat** expresses equal confidence that his party will form a majority government. Excerpts from the interviews:



Q. If you win, you will be chief minister for a record fourth time. But there is also talk of huge anti-incumbency. How do you rate your chances?

A. We are doing our best to win. There is some anti-incumbency against MLAs at the local level. But our welfare schemes are good. For example, we offered universal health insurance for every category for Rs 25 lakh, going beyond the Centre's Rs 5 lakh coverage for the poor segment alone. One crore people get social security pension with an assured raise of 15 per cent annually. We have a minimum income guarantee act, also one for gig workers and have enacted a law to stop auction of farmers' land if they default on bank loans. Then, we have been giving smartphones with free data to women. Many new colleges, including for women, have been set up.

Q. But the Opposition is charging you with poor last-mile delivery of these welfare schemes.

A. That was in my second term, with the distribution of free medicines, because it took a lot of time to work out a system to procure, store and deliver right up to the neighbourhood healthcare centre. This time, we have done some extraordinary work. We even organised the rural Olympics, named after Rajiv Gandhi. In the first year in 2022, three million people participated. This year, the number nearly doubled, with grandchildren, children, parents and grandparents

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